tract the highest funding—$26 billion, to be precise. This, when, according to NASSCOM numbers, women-led startups comprise just 18 per cent of the entire ecosystem. This, despite gender-based discrimination, limited access to capital, underrepresentation in high-growth sectors and societal scepticism. Female labour force participation in India is still 40 per cent, well below the 79.1 per cent for men. Women aged 15-59 spent about 305 minutes per day on unpaid domestic services in 2024; 41 per cent of women aged 15-59 participated in caregiving for household members. What gender parity can achieve bears repetition—it can boost India's GDP by 27 per cent, says the IMF; bringing 50 per cent of women into the active workforce can spike annual GDP growth by 1 to 1.5 percentage points, rules the World Bank.

Breaking the Mould

There are other areas where women are still ploughing a lonely furrow. Like in science and technology. Female presence in the country's research workforce remains woefully inadequate at a mere 18.6 per cent of the total—in China, it is 45.8 per cent; in the US, 27-35 per cent. But then some women prefer the quiet. Like in the wilderness. Barkha Subba found her calling there, taking up the cause of saving the Himalayan Salamander, the small, brightly-coloured lizard-like semi-aquatic amphibian. Ornithologist Parveen Shaikh did the same for the endangered Indian Skimmer, a riverine bird with its bright-orange scissors-bill, and both won the prestigious Whitley Awards this year. "Science and conservation need more women, not only as participants, but as researchers, leaders and decision-makers," says Dr Subba.

Women are indeed breaking barriers everywhere, even in our male-dominated defence forces. Theirs may currently be just a foot in the door: 3.8 per cent officers in the Indian army, 6 per cent in the Indian Navy and 13 per cent officers in the Indian Air Force. For context, the US has 19 per cent, or 400,000 women, serving in active duty and reserve roles. But Indian women are now getting out there on the scene of battle, whether as fighter pilots or as soldiers. Squadron Leader Bhawana Kanth recently became a one-woman elite club of 'Top Gun' fighter pilots eligible to lead combat missions. Her compatriots in the navy—Lieutenant Commanders Dilna K. and Roopa A.—conquered a frontier on the high seas, becoming the first women to circumnavigate the world on a double-handed voyage.

MILES TO GO

18
PER CENT
Share of women-led or -founded startups in the entire ecosystem

16.7-20
PER CENT
Female presence in the country's research workforce, compared to 45.8 per cent in China and 27-35 per cent in US

11,000
WOMEN
officers in the Indian defence forces: 3.8 per cent of them in the Indian army, 6 per cent in the navy and 13 per cent in the air force

12-15
PER CENT
Key creative and leadership positions women hold in the Indian media and entertainment industry

The Creative Cohort

When it comes to the arts, women play an outsized role in keeping alive a nation's cultural heritage, whether it is popular entertainment or the classical arts. Kapila Venu is doing exactly that with Koodiyattam, a 2,000-year-old Kerala theatre tradition that is not just physically demanding but also a test of endurance, with a single performance sometimes going up to a month. In cinema, voices from the margins are increasingly making themselves heard, like the award-winning northeastern filmmakers Tribeny Rai and Rima Das. Also breaking Bollywood's stranglehold are heroines of south Indian cinema—Rashmika Mandanna and Kalyani Priyadarshan—who are seamlessly wooing audiences across linguistic barriers.

But while much has changed, much has also remained the same. An outsider in Bollywood still has to work doubly harder than a child born in the industry. #MeToo is a reality that has not gone anywhere. Pay parity with male counterparts remains a distant dream, especially for the countless artistes who work behind the scenes. The situation is no better at the leadership level; women hold only about 12-15 per cent of key creative and leadership positions—such as heads of department, directors, writers, and senior executive roles—in the Indian media and entertainment industry. It's a situation that women have long accepted. Many have chosen the indie route, others are going OTT, and a select few are fighting it out. Like Sanya Malhotra. She has built enough equity through grit and gumption to be her own woman in the big bad world of Bollywood. "Most women often suffer from the imposter syndrome," she says. "Kick it away. Trust yourself and your gut feeling." It's a worthy thought for women across the country this Independence Day, and in the years to come. ■